

Family Paradisaeidae

Birds of paradise

Length 4¾–39 in (12–100 cm)

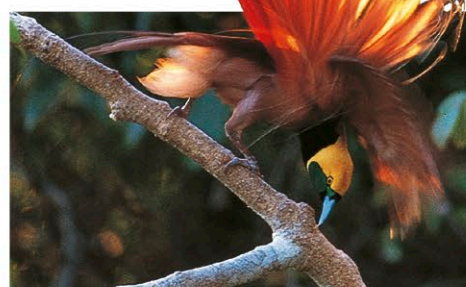
Species 41



Birds of paradise are renowned for the spectacularly beautiful and ornate plumage of the males, which is used in display, although in a few species the sexes are alike. Birds in this family differ in size, and have extremely variable tail lengths. Some species have short, straight bills, whereas others have long, curved ones. Most, however, have rounded wings and strong legs and feet, and use loud calls to attract mates. The majority of birds of paradise are found in New Guinea, mostly in wet montane forests. It is possible that the scarcity of natural mammalian predators on this island enabled these birds to evolve their flamboyant displays; males of some species court females on or close to the ground. The members of this family feed

mainly on fruit. Their nests are typically bulky, made of leaves, ferns, and twigs, and are generally placed in tree forks. Their voices vary from soft, drawn-out calls to loud, explosive sounds like a gun being fired.

scarlet-pink
plumes emerge
from under the wings



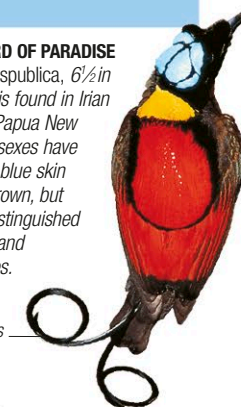
KING BIRD OF PARADISE
In a spectacular courtship display, the male bird expands his feathers and appears almost spherical, waving his green rackets above his head. *Cicinnurus regius* is 6½ in (16–17 cm) long, and its 2 thin tail feathers add another 5½ in (14 cm).

RAGGIANA BIRD OF PARADISE
Found only in New Guinea, *Paradisaea raggiana*, 14 in (35 cm) long, is the best-known bird of paradise. Adult males display communally in traditional lek sites, where up to 20 birds will congregate.

2 long tail
feathers with
rackets

WILSON'S BIRD OF PARADISE
Diphyllodes respublica, 6½ in (16 cm) long, is found in Irian Jaya but not Papua New Guinea. Both sexes have areas of bare blue skin on the hind crown, but the male is distinguished by red wings and spiral tail-wires.

spiral
tail-wires



GREATER BIRD OF PARADISE
Found on the Aru Islands and in southern New Guinea, *Paradisaea apoda* is 16½–18 in (42–45 cm) long. During courtship, 12–20 males gather in a tree to dance, spreading their wings, while the dominant male stays at the center.

flank
feathers

tail streamer

Family Oriolidae

Orioles

Length 8–12 in (20–30 cm)

Species 38



The robust Old World orioles have downcurved bills and long, pointed wings. They inhabit woodland throughout Africa, Asia, New Guinea, and Australia; one species occurs in

Eurasia. Most have predominantly yellow plumage, often with black either on the head or the wings; the females are generally dull and more streaked than the males. All of them feed on insects and fruit, and one species, the black-headed oriole, also takes nectar. The distinctive, fluty songs of orioles can be heard over considerable

distances. Most of them build a deep cup nest, slung in a horizontal fork on a branch. A number of Old World orioles are migratory.

EASTERN BLACK-HEADED ORIOLE
Found in central, eastern, and southern Africa, *Oriolus larvatus* is a noisy and conspicuous species (although it often sits motionless in the canopy), with a loud, fluty call. It is 8¾ in (22 cm) in length, and feeds on seeds, crops, fruit, and caterpillars.



Family Dicruridae

Drongos

Length 7–28 in (18–72 cm)

Species 25



The drongos, which occur in Africa, Asia, and Australia, have long, forked tails, and in all but 2 cases, are glossy black. Their stout bills are arched and slightly hooked, with a small notch, and the nostrils are often concealed by dense feathers. Drongos are mainly woodland birds, but are also found in open country with scattered trees, up

to a height of 10,900 ft (3,300 m). These insectivorous birds also feed on lizards and small birds. They feed like flycatchers—flying out from a branch to snatch prey and returning to devour it—and are well known for chasing birds of prey, which may be several times their own size.

CRESTED DRONGO
Confined to the Comoro Islands and Madagascar, *Dicrurus forficatus* is the only drongo in these countries. It is 10 in (25 cm) long, and has a striking crest which sticks up from the base of the bird's bill.



Family Monarchidae

Monarchs

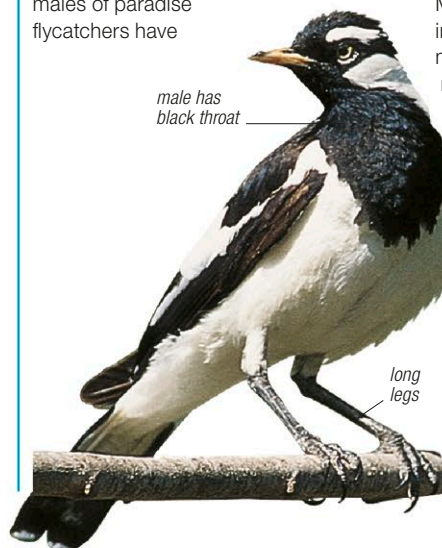
Length 4¾–12 in (12–30 cm)

Species 101



Found in Africa, Asia, and Australia, these are mostly nonmigratory birds of rain forest, open woodland, and shrub savannah. Most monarchs have the broad bill typical of a true flycatcher (Family Muscipidae) but they are not related to them. They have instead evolved from crowlike ancestors. They have evolved this way because of similar foraging habits: catching insects, such as moths, bees, and dragonflies, by making sallies into the air. Other members of the family have chunkier bills for tackling fruit, probing rotten wood—or for exploiting a more opportunistic diet. Their songs are typically weak, but some species have a loud, forceful song. Sexes are alike or strikingly different: males of paradise flycatchers have

male has
black throat



long
legs



AFRICAN PARADISE FLYCATCHER
Terpsiphone viridis is 16 in (40 cm) in length, with the male's tail up to 8 in (20 cm) long. The tails of both sexes trail over the side of the small nest cup. This flycatcher is found in forests and riverside woodland, in sub-Saharan Africa.

longer streamerlike tails and in certain species have variable color morphs. Most monarchs build their cuplike nests in tree forks or between twigs, but the magpie-lark is notable for plastering its nest with mud. This behavior led it to be classified with two other Australian mud-nesters (the apostlebird and white-winged chough), before studies of its DNA revealed its true affinities with monarchs. Fantails (Rhipiduridae) were formerly classified with monarchs, before being allocated their own family.

MAGPIE-LARK
Common in Australia near surface water, *Grallina cyanoleuca* is 11½ in (29 cm) long with a loud, piping, 5-note call. It has adapted to urban spaces and can be seen feeding at roadsides.